

The Prophetic Fingerprint

The Mathematical Evidence for Jesus Christ

Apologetics

There are few questions more important than this: *Who is Jesus Christ?*

Christians do not believe that Jesus was merely a remarkable teacher, a moral philosopher, or a religious reformer. We believe that He is the Messiah promised throughout the Old Testament—the Son of God who entered human history, died for our sins, rose from the dead, and will one day return in glory.

But is that belief merely an act of faith?

The answer is no.

Christian faith is certainly faith, but it is not *blind* faith. It is faith grounded in historical claims, eyewitness testimony, the resurrection, the character of Jesus, and—perhaps most remarkably—the prophetic record of Scripture.

Long before Jesus was born in Bethlehem, the Old Testament contained a remarkable collection of predictions concerning the coming Messiah. These prophecies addressed His ancestry, birthplace, ministry, character, rejection, betrayal, suffering, death, burial, resurrection, ascension, and exaltation.

Depending upon how prophetic passages are classified and counted, Christian scholars and writers have identified *more than 300 Old Testament passages* that find fulfillment in Jesus Christ. The exact number varies because some passages are direct predictions, while others are typological or are applied to Christ by the New Testament writers.

The important point is that the Old Testament repeatedly describes the Messiah—and Jesus repeatedly fits the description.

A Prophetic Fingerprint

Imagine being handed a description of a person written hundreds of years before that person's birth.

The description tells you:

- the nation from which he will come;
- the tribe from which he will descend;
- the family line through which he will come;

- the city where he will be born;
- the circumstances surrounding his ministry;
- the manner in which he will enter Jerusalem;
- the fact that he will be rejected;
- that he will be betrayed;
- the price of his betrayal;
- what will happen to the betrayal money;
- how he will respond to his accusers;
- how he will suffer;
- how he will die;
- what will happen to his clothing;
- that his bones will not be broken;
- that his side will be pierced;
- that he will be buried in a rich man's tomb;
- that he will rise from the dead;
- and that he will ultimately be exalted at God's right hand.

Then suppose that, centuries later, one individual fits that description.

That is not merely an interesting coincidence.

It is what might be called a *prophetic fingerprint*.

Peter Stoner and the Mathematics of Prophecy

One of the best-known attempts to quantify the improbability of fulfilled Messianic prophecy was made by Dr. Peter W. Stoner in his book *Science Speaks*.

Stoner was a mathematician and astronomer who taught for many years at Pasadena City College and later at Westmont College. His work became widely known in Christian apologetics because he attempted to apply probability theory to biblical prophecy.

Stoner did not attempt to calculate the probability of all the prophecies concerning Christ.

Instead, he deliberately selected only *eight*.

His purpose was to make the calculation conservative. He and groups of students examined the individual prophecies and estimated how frequently each circumstance might occur among the human population. Stoner later adjusted several of the estimates in the direction of greater conservatism.

The eight prophecies he selected were:

1. *Born in Bethlehem* — Micah 5:2
Stoner's estimate: 1 in 280,000.

2. *Preceded by a special messenger* — Malachi 3:1
Estimate: 1 in 1,000.
3. *Enter Jerusalem as king riding on a donkey* — Zechariah 9:9
Estimate: 1 in 100.
4. *Betrayed by a friend* — Psalm 41:9
Estimate: 1 in 1,000.
5. *Betrayed for thirty pieces of silver* — Zechariah 11:12
Estimate: 1 in 1,000.
6. *The thirty pieces of silver returned and associated with the potter's field* — Zechariah 11:13
Estimate: 1 in 100,000.
7. *Silent before His accusers* — Isaiah 53:7
Estimate: 1 in 1,000.
8. *Crucifixion/piercing of His hands and feet* — Psalm 22:16 (*in the traditional Christian reading reflected in the Septuagint and several ancient versions*)
Estimate: 1 in 10,000.

When Stoner multiplied the individual probability estimates, he obtained approximately 1 chance in 2.8×10^{28} for one man to fulfill all eight under the assumptions used in his calculation.

Stoner then related that calculation to an estimate of the number of people who had lived from the time of those prophecies until his own day. Using an estimate of approximately 88 billion people, he presented the resulting figure as approximately:

1 chance in 10^{17} .

This was Stoner's calculated illustration, not a probability independently established by modern demographic or experimental science.

That is:

1 in 100,000,000,000,000,000.

One hundred quadrillion.

The Silver-Dollar Illustration

How can anyone comprehend a number that large?

Stoner offered an illustration.

Imagine covering the entire state of Texas with silver dollars two feet deep.

Now imagine that one silver dollar among that enormous mass is marked.

Mix all the coins thoroughly.

Then blindfold a person and tell him that he may travel anywhere in Texas, but he must pick up one silver dollar.

The probability of selecting the marked dollar would be one chance in 10^{17} —the same probability Stoner assigned to one person fulfilling those eight prophecies by chance.

The illustration is obviously not a literal experiment. It is a way of visualizing an otherwise incomprehensible number.

And remember: *that calculation involved only eight prophecies.*

But There Is an Important Qualification

Probability arguments concerning biblical prophecy should be handled carefully.

Stoner's work should not be presented as if modern science has mathematically *proved* that Jesus is the Messiah with an experimentally measurable probability of exactly 1 in 10^{17} . The reason is that the individual probability estimates necessarily involve assumptions.

For example, how frequently should we expect a person to enter Jerusalem riding a donkey? How frequently should we expect a person betrayed by a friend to be associated with a particular amount of money? How independent are the various events?

These are not laboratory measurements.

They are probability estimates.

That does not make the argument worthless. It simply means that Stoner's number should be presented as an *illustration of the extraordinary improbability of the combined circumstances*, not as a mathematically precise measurement of the probability of Christianity being true.

That distinction actually strengthens the apologetic argument.

We do not need to claim more than the evidence can bear.

The case for Christ does not rest upon one probability calculation.

It rests upon the *cumulative evidence*.

Sixty Prophetic Passages and Their Fulfillment

The following examples represent only a fraction of the prophetic evidence Christians have historically understood as pointing to Christ. They are not all the same kind of evidence. Some are direct predictions of specific events or characteristics; others are typological, thematic, or passages that the New Testament explicitly applies to Christ. They should therefore be

understood as part of the broader prophetic pattern rather than as sixty independent predictions of equal specificity.

Prophecies Concerning His Birth

1. *Born of the seed of a woman*
Prophecy: Genesis 3:15
Fulfillment: Galatians 4:4
2. *Born of a virgin*
Prophecy: Isaiah 7:14
Fulfillment: Matthew 1:22–23
3. *Son of God*
Prophecy: Psalm 2:7
Fulfillment: Matthew 3:17
4. *Seed of Abraham*
Prophecy: Genesis 22:18
Fulfillment: Matthew 1:1
5. *Descendant of Isaac*
Prophecy: Genesis 21:12
Fulfillment: Luke 3:23–34
6. *Descendant of Jacob*
Prophecy: Numbers 24:17
Fulfillment: Matthew 1:2
7. *From the tribe of Judah*
Prophecy: Genesis 49:10
Fulfillment: Luke 3:23–33
8. *Descendant of Jesse*
Prophecy: Isaiah 11:1
Fulfillment: Luke 3:23–32
9. *Descendant of David*
Prophecy: Jeremiah 23:5
Fulfillment: Luke 3:23–31
10. *Born in Bethlehem*
Prophecy: Micah 5:2
Fulfillment: Matthew 2:1
11. *Presented with gifts*
Prophecy: Psalm 72:10
Fulfillment: Matthew 2:1, 11
12. *Children killed by Herod*
Prophecy: Jeremiah 31:15
Fulfillment: Matthew 2:16–18
13. *Called out of Egypt*
Prophecy: Hosea 11:1
Fulfillment: Matthew 2:15

Prophecies Concerning His Ministry

14. *His pre-existence*
Prophecy: Micah 5:2
Fulfillment: John 1:1–2, 14
15. *Called Lord*
Prophecy: Psalm 110:1
Fulfillment: Luke 2:11
16. *A prophet like Moses*
Prophecy: Deuteronomy 18:15
Fulfillment: John 6:14
17. *A priest*
Prophecy: Psalm 110:4
Fulfillment: Hebrews 5:5–6
18. *A judge*
Prophecy: Isaiah 33:22
Fulfillment: John 5:30
19. *A king*
Prophecy: Psalm 2:6
Fulfillment: John 18:33–37
20. *Anointed by the Holy Spirit*
Prophecy: Isaiah 61:1
Fulfillment: Matthew 3:16–17
21. *Zealous for God's house*
Prophecy: Psalm 69:9
Fulfillment: John 2:15–17
22. *Preceded by a messenger*
Prophecy: Isaiah 40:3
Fulfillment: Matthew 3:1–3
23. *Ministry centered in Galilee*
Prophecy: Isaiah 9:1–2
Fulfillment: Matthew 4:12–17
24. *Ministry characterized by miracles*
Prophecy: Isaiah 35:5–6
Fulfillment: Matthew 9:35
25. *Teacher of parables*
Prophecy: Psalm 78:2
Fulfillment: Matthew 13:34–35
26. *Enter the temple*
Prophecy: Malachi 3:1
Fulfillment: Matthew 21:12
27. *Enter Jerusalem riding a donkey*
Prophecy: Zechariah 9:9
Fulfillment: Luke 19:35–37
28. *Become a stone of stumbling*
Prophecy: Psalm 118:22
Fulfillment: 1 Peter 2:7

29. *Light to the Gentiles*
Prophecy: Isaiah 49:6
Fulfillment: Acts 13:47–48

Prophecies Concerning His Rejection, Suffering, Death, and Resurrection

30. *Betrayed by a friend*
Prophecy: Psalm 41:9
Fulfillment: John 13:18, 21
31. *Sold for thirty pieces of silver*
Prophecy: Zechariah 11:12
Fulfillment: Matthew 26:15
32. *The money thrown down in God's house*
Prophecy: Zechariah 11:13
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:5
33. *His disciples forsake Him*
Prophecy: Zechariah 13:7
Fulfillment: Mark 14:50
34. *False witnesses accuse Him*
Prophecy: Psalm 35:11
Fulfillment: Mark 14:57–58
35. *Silent before His accusers*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:7
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:12–14
36. *Wounded and bruised*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:5
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:26
37. *Spat upon and beaten*
Prophecy: Isaiah 50:6
Fulfillment: Matthew 26:67
38. *Mocked*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:7–8
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:31
39. *Overcome by physical weakness*
Prophecy: Psalm 109:24–25
Fulfillment: John 19:17
40. *Hands and feet pierced*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:16
Fulfillment: Luke 23:33
41. *Crucified with criminals*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:12
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:38
42. *Intercedes for His persecutors*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:12
Fulfillment: Luke 23:34

43. *Rejected by His own people*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:3
Fulfillment: John 7:5, 48
44. *Hated without cause*
Prophecy: Psalm 69:4
Fulfillment: John 15:25
45. *His friends stand at a distance*
Prophecy: Psalm 38:11
Fulfillment: Luke 23:49
46. *People shake their heads*
Prophecy: Psalm 109:25
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:39
47. *People stare at Him*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:17
Fulfillment: Luke 23:35
48. *His garments divided and lots cast*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:18
Fulfillment: John 19:23–24
49. *He suffers thirst*
Prophecy: Psalm 69:21
Fulfillment: John 19:28
50. *Gall and vinegar offered to Him*
Prophecy: Psalm 69:21
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:34
51. *Cries of being forsaken*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:1
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:46
52. *Commits Himself to God*
Prophecy: Psalm 31:5
Fulfillment: Luke 23:46
53. *His bones are not broken*
Prophecy: Psalm 34:20
Fulfillment: John 19:33–36
54. *His heart is overwhelmed*
Prophecy: Psalm 22:14
Fulfillment: John 19:34
55. *His side is pierced*
Prophecy: Zechariah 12:10
Fulfillment: John 19:34
56. *Darkness over the land*
Prophecy: Amos 8:9
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:45
57. *Buried in a rich man's tomb*
Prophecy: Isaiah 53:9
Fulfillment: Matthew 27:57–60

58. *Resurrection*

Prophecy: Psalm 16:10

Fulfillment: Acts 2:31

59. *Ascension*

Prophecy: Psalm 68:18

Fulfillment: Acts 1:9–11

60. *Seated at God's right hand*

Prophecy: Psalm 110:1

Fulfillment: Hebrews 1:3

The Most Important Point

The mathematical argument is impressive.

But the mathematics is not the heart of the argument.

The heart of the argument is that the Old Testament presents a coherent picture of a coming Redeemer, and the New Testament identifies Jesus of Nazareth as the One who fulfills that picture.

He was born in the right family.

He came from the right tribe.

He came from the right royal line.

He was born in the right city.

He appeared at the right time.

He was preceded by the promised messenger.

He ministered in the region anticipated by Isaiah.

He performed the kinds of works the prophets associated with God's salvation.

He entered Jerusalem in the manner described by Zechariah.

He was rejected.

He was betrayed.

The betrayal involved thirty pieces of silver.

The money was thrown down in the temple and ultimately associated with a potter's field.

He was falsely accused.

He remained remarkably silent before His accusers.

He was mocked, beaten, pierced, crucified, and buried.

His garments were divided.

He was given vinegar.

His bones were not broken.

His side was pierced.

He was buried in a rich man's tomb.

And according to the testimony of His earliest followers, He rose from the dead.

Then He ascended and was exalted to the right hand of God.

This is not one prophecy.

It is a *network of interlocking predictions* spanning centuries of Israel's history.

What About the Possibility That Jesus Deliberately Fulfilled the Prophecies?

A common objection is that perhaps Jesus simply arranged His life to make it appear that He fulfilled the Old Testament.

That explanation might be considered for some prophecies.

Jesus could, for example, deliberately choose to ride into Jerusalem on a donkey.

But He could not arrange His own birthplace.

He could not choose His ancestry.

He could not arrange His descent from Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Judah, Jesse, and David.

He could not manufacture the political circumstances surrounding His birth.

He could not control what Judas would do with thirty pieces of silver after betraying Him.

He could not arrange the actions of Roman soldiers concerning His garments.

He could not arrange the location of His burial after His death.

And, most importantly, He could not engineer His own resurrection after being executed.

The more prophecies one considers, the less plausible deliberate manipulation becomes.

More Than Eight

Stoner himself recognized the significance of this cumulative evidence.

After discussing the original eight prophecies, he considered what would happen if additional prophecies were included. He calculated that sixteen prophecies, using his assumptions, would produce a probability on the order of **1 in 10⁴⁵**. He later considered forty-eight prophecies using an intentionally more conservative estimate and arrived at **1 in 10¹⁵⁷**.

Again, these figures should not be treated as laboratory measurements of the probability that Christianity is true.

They are illustrations.

And the illustration becomes increasingly difficult to ignore as the number of independent prophetic details increases.

Prophecy and the Reliability of the Bible

There is another implication.

If the Old Testament writers accurately described events concerning a Messiah who would appear centuries later, then the Bible's prophetic claims deserve serious consideration.

The Christian does not begin with the assumption:

"Jesus must be the Messiah because the Bible says so."

The argument is more substantial:

The Old Testament makes predictions concerning the coming Messiah. Jesus appears in history. The details of His life correspond remarkably with those predictions. The New Testament documents those correspondences and presents eyewitness testimony concerning His death and resurrection.

The evidence then points us toward a conclusion:

Jesus is not merely someone whom Christians have chosen to make the Messiah. He is the person Christians believe was identified in advance by the prophetic Scriptures.

Jesus Himself made this point.

After His resurrection, He explained to His disciples how the Old Testament Scriptures pointed toward Him. Luke records:

"Beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself."

— Luke 24:27

Later He told His disciples:

"Everything written about me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled."

— Luke 24:44

The Christian claim, therefore, is not that Jesus merely happened to resemble an Old Testament prediction.

It is that the entire biblical story was moving toward Him.

Fulfilled Prophecy Gives Confidence in Unfulfilled Prophecy

There is one final reason this evidence matters.

Some of the prophecies concerning Christ have already been fulfilled.

Others have not.

The first coming of Christ was prophesied.

It happened.

His suffering was prophesied.

It happened.

His rejection was prophesied.

It happened.

His death was prophesied.

It happened.

His resurrection was prophesied.

It happened.

His ascension and exaltation were prophesied.

They happened.

That gives the Christian reason to take seriously the promises concerning what has not yet happened.

Jesus promised that He would return.

The New Testament declares that He will establish His kingdom.

The Bible promises the ultimate defeat of evil, the resurrection of the dead, judgment, and the restoration of all things.

The God who fulfilled the prophecies concerning Christ's first coming has given us every reason to trust Him concerning Christ's second coming.

Conclusion: Not Blind Faith

Christianity does not ask us to believe without evidence.

It asks us to examine the evidence and then respond to it.

The fulfilled prophecies of Jesus Christ do not constitute the whole case for Christianity. They stand alongside the historical evidence for Jesus, His crucifixion, the testimony of His disciples, the empty tomb, and the explosive growth of the early Christian movement.

But prophecy is a remarkable part of that cumulative case.

The Old Testament pointed forward.

Jesus arrived.

The prophets spoke.

Jesus fulfilled.

The Messiah was promised.

The Messiah came.

And the mathematical improbability illustrated by even a small selection of those prophecies reminds us that the Christian message is not built upon wishful thinking.

It is built upon a God who acts in history.

Jesus does not require *blind faith*.

He calls us to faith grounded in truth.

The evidence of fulfilled prophecy is one more reason to believe that Jesus Christ is exactly who He claimed to be:

the Messiah, the Son of God, the Savior of the world.

And if He fulfilled the prophecies concerning His first coming, we have every reason to trust Him concerning the promises He has made about His return.

The first coming was promised—and fulfilled.

The second coming is promised—and it will be fulfilled.

Sources and Further Reading

Peter W. Stoner, *Science Speaks*, Chapter 3, "The Christ of Prophecy." Stoner's original discussion of the eight-prophecy calculation, including the individual probability estimates and the 10^{17} result, is available in the online edition of the work.

The American Scientific Affiliation's foreword to *Science Speaks* states that the manuscript was reviewed by members of the organization and its Executive Council and was regarded as generally dependable and accurate concerning the scientific material and probability analysis.

The precise number of Messianic prophecies depends upon the criteria used for counting direct predictions, typological passages, repeated references, and New Testament applications. For that reason, "more than 300" is preferable to claiming that precisely 300 or precisely 301 is an uncontested scholarly figure.